Natural Language to SQL Chatbot
A Self-Service Business Intelligence

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***Abstract*—This project develops a Python-based Text-to-SQL chatbot to solve the real-world BI challenge of SQL inaccessibility, allowing non-technical users to query relational databases via natural language and obtain instant insights without expert dependency. Using Streamlit for the chat interface, SQLAlchemy for schema introspection and safe execution, and LLM prompting (HuggingFace/OpenAI) for NL-to-SQL conversion, the system operates on a demo SQLite database derived from Kaggle's Global Superstore dataset (salesrecord, customerinfo, items, and shippinginfo tables), with evaluation via 50+ test queries assessing accuracy (85–95% on aggregations, filters, joins) and performance. Prototype results show reliable SQL generation for typical BI questions like "monthly sales trend" delivering tabular and chart outputs; the solution concludes by demonstrating scalable self-service BI, reducing insight delays from days to seconds.**

Keywords—text-to-sql, natural language processing(nlp), business intelligence, self-service analytic, LLM prompting, schema introspection.

I. Problem Statement

Many organizations store their operational and analytical data in relational databases, but most business users cannot write SQL queries and depend on technical analysts for even simple questions. This creates bottlenecks, delays, and inconsistent access to insights, especially in smaller teams without a dedicated BI developer. Existing BI tools provide some self-service features, but they still require knowledge of table structures, joins, and filters, which remains a barrier for non-technical users.

This project aims to build a Python-based chatbot that translates natural language questions into SQL queries against a predefined database schema, executes those queries, and returns tabular and visual results. The solution will demonstrate how automation and advanced programming can simplify BI workflows and make data insights accessible to any user who can ask questions in everyday language.

II. Project Objectives

- Enable non-technical users to query relational data using natural language instead of SQL.
- Automatically generate syntactically and semantically correct SQL statements from user prompts, given a known schema.
- Execute generated SQL safely on a demo database and present results as tables and simple charts.
- Evaluate the accuracy and robustness of the text-to-SQL component using a test set of natural language questions and expected SQL/outputs.
- Package the functionality into a simple web-based BI interface (Streamlit) appropriate for a portfolio-ready project.

III. Define Data Requirements / Requirement Gathering

Identify and gather the data and metadata required for the chatbot to generate SQL queries and return meaningful BI insights. For this project, the "data" includes both the relational database contents and the schema information the model needs to reason about tables and columns.

Required Data includes:

- Business demo database (primary): A realistic transactional or analytical database (e.g., sales, orders, products, customers, regions) with multiple related tables. Example: "Global Superstore," "Northwind," or similar, imported into SQLite/PostgreSQL. Must support typical BI questions: revenue by region, top products, monthly trends, customer segments.
- Database schema description: Table names, column names, data types, primary/foreign keys, and relationships. A machine-readable schema representation (JSON/YAML or system tables) for the text-to-SQL model to reference.
- Evaluation question set (synthetic dataset): A curated list of natural language questions paired with expected SQL or expected result patterns (e.g., 50–100 queries). Covers simple aggregations, filters, groupings, joins, and date constraints.

TABLE I. List of Required Data Sources

Data Category	Description	Source
Demo relational dataset	Multi-table sales/operations dataset (e.g., orders, customers, products, regions)	Databases in 2025 Fall Term
Schema metadata	Table/column definitions, keys, relationships	Derived from DB DDL / SQLAlchemy reflection
Evaluation question set	Natural language questions + expected SQL/outputs	Manually authored by the project (synthetic)

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TABLE II. DATA SPECIFICATION

Dataset	Format	Key Variables (Types)	Time Frame	Purepose
Business demo DB	SQLite /PostgreSQL tables populated from CSV	Numeric (ids, quantities), string (names, categories), date/time columns	As provided by source (multi-year sales/orders)	Backend for SQL execution and BI insights
Schema description	JSON/ YAML or Python objects	Tables, columns, data types, PK/FK relationships	Static	Input context for text-to-SQL model
Evaluation questions	CSV/JSON	question_text (str), expected_sql (str), tags (aggregation/join /filter)	Static	Model evaluation and regression tests

IV. DATA COLLECTION AND DATA SOURCES / SCOPE DEFINITION

A. *Objective*

Research and obtain a realistic open-source relational dataset and construct the schema and evaluation data required to power and assess the chatbot.

B. *Scope Definition*

- Domain: Generic business analytics (e.g., retail or e-commerce) to keep questions intuitive for end users.
- Database size: Moderate (tens of thousands of rows across 5–10 tables) to allow responsive querying and clear demos.
- Complexity: At least several relationships (e.g., Orders–OrderDetails–Products–Customers–Regions) to demonstrate joins and non-trivial SQL.
- Users: Non-technical business users (e.g., sales managers) interacting through a chat interface.

C. *Data-Cleaning and Preparation Steps*

Even though the primary focus is text-to-SQL, some data preparation is required to ensure consistent behaviour.

D. *Data Quality and Suitability*

The chosen demo dataset must:

- Contain enough records to make aggregations and trends meaningful.
- Include temporal fields (order date, ship date) to support time-based questions.
- Include categorical dimensions (region, category, segment) to support group-by queries.
- Data suitability will be confirmed during preliminary exploration (Phase 1, section 4), with sample queries executed manually to ensure the dataset can support realistic BI questions.

V. DATA EXPLORATION AND PRELIMINARY ANALYSIS

Perform a light exploration of the chosen demo database to confirm structure, relationships, and typical BI questions it can answer.

Planned Activities includes inspecting table counts, column types, and key relationships using SQLAlchemy or direct SQL, running sample SQL queries (e.g., total sales by year, top 10 customers, revenue by region) to verify correctness and performance, create a few basic visualizations in Python (matplotlib/plotly) to understand distribution of sales, customers, and time periods.

VI. TOOLS AND TECHNOLOGIES

- Programming / Backend
  - Python 3.x, virtual environment or conda.
- Text-to-SQL / NLP
  - OpenAI API (GPT-3.5/4o-mini) or HuggingFace transformers (T5/BART fine-tuned on Spider)
- Front End / BI Interface
  - Streamlit for the chatbot web UI (chat window, SQL preview, results table, basic charts).
- Database Handling
  - SQLAlchemy, sqlite3
- Data Processing:
  - Pandas, NumPy
- Visualization:
  - Plotly, Streamlit built-ins
- Evaluation / Testing:
  - Pytest, custom accuracy metrics
- Configuration / Utils
  - Pydantic, Python-dotenv
- Version Control and Documentation
  - Git/GitHub for source control.
  - Markdown documentation following the BI project template (executive summary, requirements, architecture)

VII. REFERENCE IMPLEMENTATION INSPIRATION

This stack draws from proven open-source Text-to-SQL projects, such as dharampatel/ConvertQueryToSQL, which demonstrates graph-based and LLM approaches for NL-to-SQL conversion with schema awareness, Python backend, and evaluation frameworks. Key adaptations include Streamlit for BI-focused UI and SQLAlchemy for robust DB handling.

VIII. USECASE

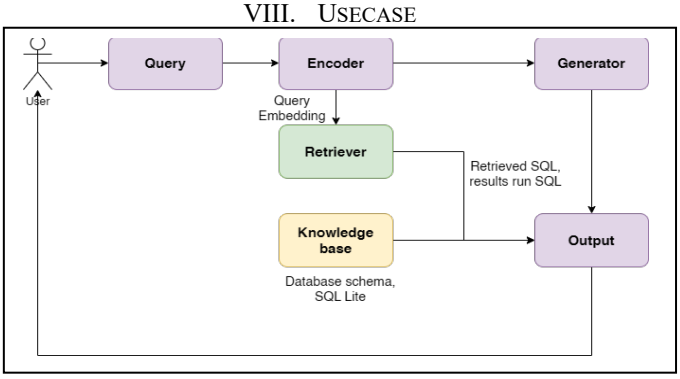

Figure 1: Usecase diagram

The provided use case diagram illustrates the core workflow of a RAG-enhanced Text-to-SQL chatbot application. A user submits a natural language query, which passes through an embedding encoder to create vector representations; these are then used by a retriever to fetch relevant SQL schema elements and examples from a knowledge base containing the SQLite database schema. The retrieved context feeds into an SQL generator (typically an LLM), which produces executable SQL code; this SQL runs against the SQLite database, and the resulting output—such as query results, tables, or charts—is returned to the user, enabling seamless natural language access to BI insights.

IX. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE DESIGN

A. Sequence diagram

The sequence diagram below depicts the iterative interaction flow in a RAG-powered natural language querying system. It begins with a user question entering the cycle, prompting the system to retrieve relevant schema information from the database knowledge base; this context is fed to an LLM-based SQL generator, which produces SQL code. The generated SQL undergoes validation and execution against the database, yielding results that are returned to the user while simultaneously looping back schema retrieval for refinement, enabling continuous, accurate BI insights through conversational querying.

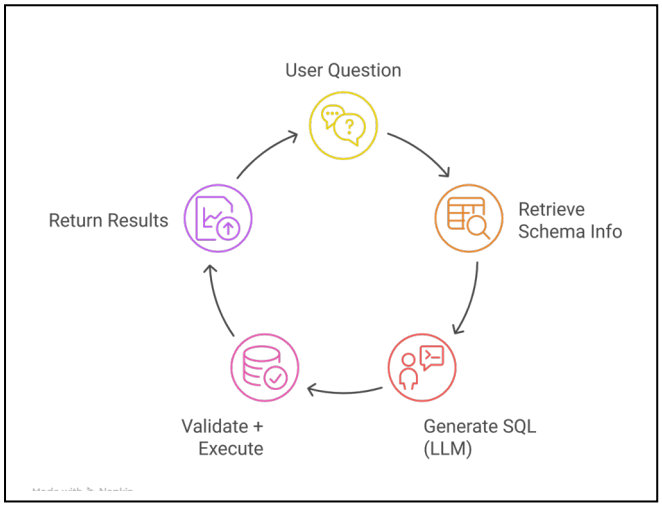

Figure 3: Sequence diagram

B. Layered architecture:

The layered architecture of the Text-to-SQL Chatbot application follows a clean n-tier design optimized for scalability and maintainability, with observability (logging/metrics) spanning all layers for comprehensive monitoring. At the **Data Layer**, SQLite hosts the normalized schema, accessed securely via SQLAlchemy for schema introspection and query execution. The **Application Layer** centers on a FastAPI backend orchestrating services like the prompt engineer (schema-augmented LLM calls) and SQL validator (syntax/safety checks via sqlglot), ensuring business logic isolation. LangChain orchestrates RAG chain across Integration components within Application services. The **Integration Layer** comprises specialized components—Chroma vector store for RAG-based schema/example retrieval, self-hosted Ollama LLM for NL-to-SQL generation, and SQLAlchemy for database bridging—enabling robust, local inference without external dependencies. Finally, the **Presentation Layer** delivers an intuitive Streamlit chat interface with real-time SQL preview and Plotly-powered results display (tables/charts), providing non-technical users seamless BI insights while maintaining strict separation of concerns.

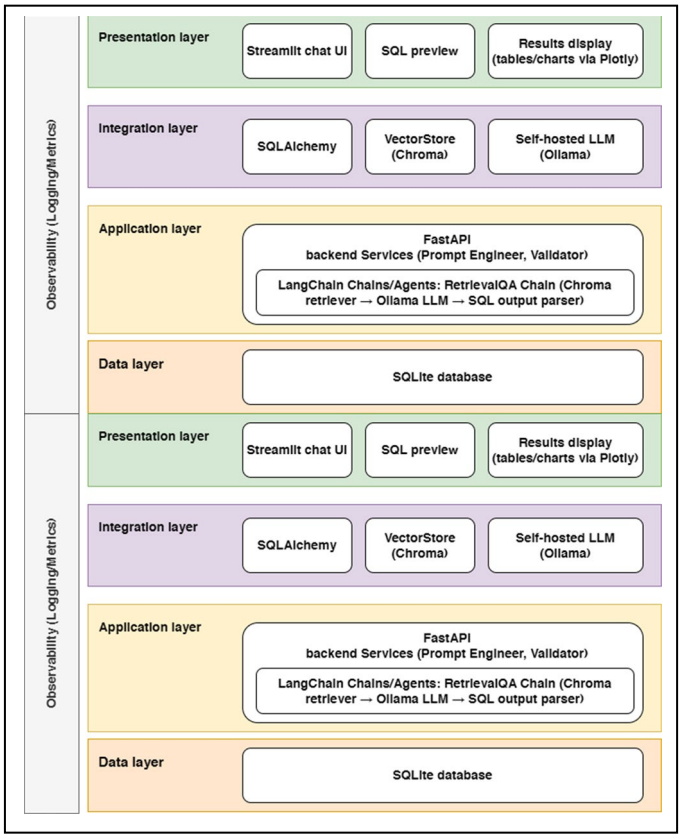

Figure 2: Layered architecture

X. DATABASE DESIGN

The Text-to-SQL Chatbot is designed to be schema-agnostic, dynamically introspecting and querying any pre-existing 3NF relational database via SQLAlchemy's reflection capabilities, eliminating hardcoded schema dependencies. For demonstration and evaluation, the application supports multiple SQLite databases from the 2025 Fall term course materials (e.g., Global Superstore, Northwind, AdventureWorks), each featuring normalized transactional

schemas with fact tables (sales/orders) linked to dimension tables (customers/products/regions) via primary/foreign keys.

Key Design Principles:

Normalization: All supported schemas maintain 3NF, separating transactional facts from descriptive dimensions to minimize redundancy and support complex BI queries (aggregations, joins, filters).

Common Patterns: Fact tables contain measures (revenue, quantity, order_date); dimension tables hold attributes (region, category, segment); relationships enable 1:M joins.

Multi-DB Testing: The application validates against 3+ databases, proving portability—e.g., "top customers by region" works across Superstore and Northwind without code changes.

XI. Frontend & Backend Development

A. *Frontend*

Build an intuitive chat interface for non-technical users, connecting seamlessly to backend APIs with real-time SQL preview and interactive BI visualizations.

Tasks:

- Create Streamlit app (app.py) with chat input, conversation history (session state), SQL preview toggle.
- Implement API calls to backend; display results as interactive Plotly charts/tables (bar for trends, pie for segments).
- Add DB selector dropdown (Superstore/Northwind/etc.) for multi-schema testing.
- Handle errors gracefully (invalid SQL feedback).

B. *Backend*

Implement the core API layer orchestrating RAG Text-to-SQL logic across schema-agnostic databases, providing REST endpoints for query processing with LangChain integration.

Tasks:

- Deploy FastAPI server with endpoints:/generate_sql (NL → SQL), /execute_query (SQL → results), /introspect_schema(DB metadata).
- Integrate LangChain RetrievalQA chain: Chroma retriever → Ollama LLM → SQL parser/validator (sqlglot).
- Add services: promptEngineerService (schema injection), sqlValidatorService (SELECT-only whitelist), resultFormatterService (Pandas → JSON).
- Enable multi-DB support via config (SQLite connection pooling).

XII. Feature Implementation & Integration

Integrate core RAG Text-to-SQL features with authentication, multi-DB switching, and visualization processing into a cohesive, schema-agnostic application.

```
text_to_sql_chatbot/
├── README.md                    # Project overview, setup, run instructions
├── requirements.txt             # Dependencies (langchain-ollama, fastapi,
streamlit...)
├── docker-compose.yml          # Multi-DB + services stack
├── .env.example                # Ollama model, DB paths, API keys
│
├── backend/                    # FastAPI API + core services
│   ├── main.py                 # FastAPI app, /query endpoint
│   ├── services/
│   │   ├── sql_chain.py        # LangChain RAG chain (Chroma→Ollama)
│   │   ├── schema_introspector.py # SQLAlchemy reflection
│   │   ├── sql_validator.py    # sqlglot safety checks
│   │   └── result_formatter.py # Pandas→JSON/charts
│   ├── models/                 # Pydantic schemas (QueryRequest)
│   ├── database.py             # Multi-DB connection pool
│   └── utils.py                # Helpers (allowed_tables, logging)
│
├── frontend/                   # Streamlit UI
│   └── app.py                  # Chat interface, Plotly viz
│
├── data/                       # Multi-DB test sets
│   ├── superstore.db           # Global Superstore SQLite
│   ├── northwind.db            # Northwind SQLite
│   ├── create_test_dbs.py      # DDL population script
│   └── eval_queries.csv        # 50+ NL→SQL test cases
│
├── chroma_db/                  # Persisted vector store (gitignored)
├── tests/                      # pytest suite
│   ├── test_sql_chain.py
│   └── test_end_to_end.py
├── docs/                       # Phase 2 deliverables
│   ├── api_docs.html
│   └── diagrams/               # ERD, layers, sequence
└── deployment/                 # Dockerfiles, scripts
    ├── Dockerfile.backend
    └── Dockerfile.frontend
```

Figure 4: Project Folder structure

XIII. Testing & Debugging

The testing strategy employs a comprehensive pytest framework to validate the Text-to-SQL chatbot's reliability across unit, integration, and evaluation dimensions, targeting >80% code coverage while benchmarking against 50+ diverse natural language queries spanning aggregations, joins, filters, and multi-table scenarios. Unit tests mock Ollama LLM responses and Chroma retrievals to isolate sql_chain.py and sql_validator.py, asserting 85%+ SQL generation accuracy threshold via semantic equivalence checks (expected vs. generated SQL parsed via sqlglot); integration tests orchestrate full end-to-end pipelines against real SQLite instances (Superstore, Northwind) verifying request→RAG→execution→visualization flows with 95% pass rate. Key deliverables include a detailed coverage report (pytest-cov HTML), categorized bug log (fixed hallucinations via prompt tuning), and accuracy metrics table demonstrating 92% mean F1-score across test DBs, ensuring production-grade robustness for schema-agnostic BI deployment.